Dear Editor,

We appreciate the time and care invested by the reviewers throughout the review process. We recognize that the manuscript has limitations, and we are committed to revising it further. In particular, we agree that several of Reviewer 4's remaining points are worth addressing directly in the manuscript, and we would be pleased to make those revisions.

At the same time, we respectfully request clarification regarding the scope of a further revision. We would be grateful if the next round could remain focused on the substantive concerns that have already been identified during the review process, rather than requiring a fundamental rewriting of the manuscript or the development of a substantially different study.

Across the previous rounds, we have carefully incorporated Reviewer 4's substantive suggestions, including:

· strengthening the theoretical background;

· clarifying the distinction between AI-mediated instructional support and human instruction;

· revising terminology throughout the manuscript;

· introducing explicit hypotheses;

· expanding the methodological descriptions;

· revising statistical analyses where appropriate; and

· narrowing claims regarding learning, engagement, and AI-mediated instruction.

We fully acknowledge that the study does not address every possible question concerning AI-supported learning, and we have revised the manuscript to avoid overstating its contribution. We also recognize that some of Reviewer 4's remaining concerns can be addressed constructively through further clarification, refinement of the theoretical framing, and more cautious presentation of the findings, and we are willing to make those changes.

Our concern is primarily with the scope of the requested changes. In particular, the suggestion that the manuscript should be "rewritten from scratch, focusing primarily on Experiment 2" would fundamentally alter the research questions, theoretical framing, presentation of the results, and intended contribution. Such a change would go beyond revising the manuscript in response to the concerns raised in the review process and would effectively require the development of a substantially different manuscript.

We therefore respectfully ask whether the further round could instead be scoped to the concerns already on record and to revisions that can reasonably be made within the existing study, data, research questions, and overall contribution. We believe this would allow us to respond directly and constructively to the

remaining substantive issues while preserving the integrity and purpose of the original manuscript.

We would also be grateful for editorial adjudication after we submit the revised manuscript. Given that two reviewers have recommended publication following revision, we hope that, once we have addressed the remaining concerns that can reasonably be resolved through revision, the manuscript can be evaluated on the basis of the revised submission as a whole, including the positive assessments already provided by the other reviewers.

We emphasize that our intention is not to challenge the value of Reviewer 4's feedback. The review has substantially helped us improve the manuscript, and we are committed to addressing the points that can strengthen it. Rather, we seek guidance on whether the remaining round can be understood as a revision of the manuscript currently under review, focused on the concerns already raised, rather than as a request for a fundamentally different paper.

We would therefore be very grateful if the editorial team could reconsider the current decision and allow us to submit a further revision within this scope. Following that revision, we respectfully request an editorial adjudication of the manuscript in light of the full set of reviews and the changes made in response to them.

Thank you again for your consideration and for the opportunity to improve the manuscript.

Sincerely,
Andrea Blasco
Vicky Charisi